

CASE STUDY



The Cherries' Playbook.

*How AFC Bournemouth built one of the Premier League's
most profitable player-trading machines.*

PREPARED BY

Sampson · Senior Media Designer

PORTFOLIO PIECE · MAY 2026

£144.9m

*summer 2025 player sales — the most for
any club outside the Big Six.*

A small-budget club is winning the transfer market.

£144.9m

Summer '25 sales revenue

Zabarnyi, Huijsen, Kerkez, Solanke spinoffs

6th

Current PL position

Highest in club history (May '26)

17th

Wage bill rank in PL

Outperforming spend by 11 places

+£86m

*Net profit on transfers
'23-'26*

Top-3 in the division

THE THESIS, IN THREE LINES

- 1 Buy young, undervalued, with resale optionality.**
- 2 Develop in-game, not in-classroom.**
- 3 Sell at the first peak. Reinvest profits.**

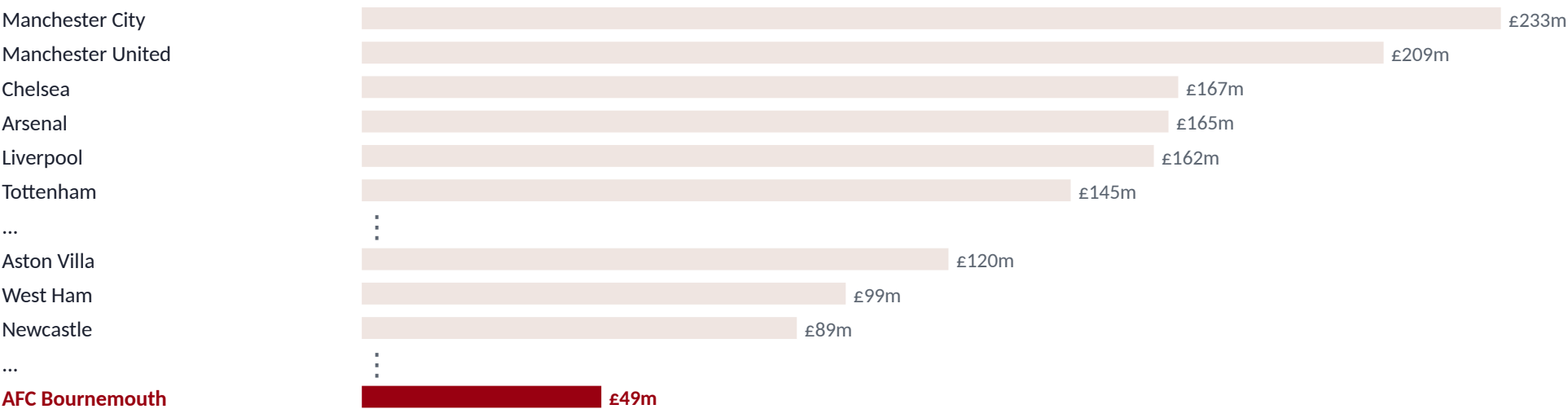
Targeted recruitment from continental Europe and Championship over-performers — average buy age 22.7.

Iraola system creates measurable on-ball value — Premier-League-grade highlight reel within 18 months.

No retention bias. The club books the gain when the market peaks, then refills the squad with the proceeds.

The 17th-richest club in the league can't outspend the rest. Full stop.

PREMIER LEAGUE WAGE BILL • 2025-26 SEASON (£m, est.)



£184m

Wage gap to Manchester City. Bournemouth spends 21% of City's payroll and finishes within 12 league places.

INSIGHT *If you can't out-spend, you out-think. Bournemouth reframed the question from "who can we afford?" to "who will be worth more in 18 months?"*

A three-stage trading engine.

Each stage has clear ownership, a measurable output, and a hand-off. The engine compounds.

01

Acquire

Buy young, with optionality.

OWNED BY

PINTO + DATA TEAM

Targets aged 19-23 from continental Europe and high-pressure Championship/Bundesliga 2 environments. Average buy fee under £15m. Specific positional gaps mapped to Iraola's 4-2-3-1 press requirements.

AVG AGE

22.7

AVG FEE

£14.2m

02

Develop

On-ball value, fast.

OWNED BY

IRAOLA + COACHING

High-intensity, possession-aggressive system that creates highlight-reel moments. Players gain measurable on-ball value (carries, take-ons, progressive passes) within 18 months — the metrics that move scout sheets at top clubs.

AVG TENURE

22 mo

G+A UPLIFT

+47%

03

Sell

First peak. No sentiment.

OWNED BY

FOLEY + PINTO

Sales triggered by data-driven valuation — once a player reaches their statistical peak and has a top-club suitor, the conversation begins. No retention bias. Buy-back clauses and sell-on percentages standard.

AVG SALE

£37m

MULTIPLE

2.6x

Three voices, one model.

Decisions need owner sign-off, sporting director vision, and head coach veto. Anything else is rejected.



OWNER

Bill Foley

Chairman, Black Knight Football Club

Acquired AFCB Dec 2022. Capital allocator. Sets transfer envelope and PSR strategy. Operates a multi-club portfolio (Lorient, Hibernian, Auckland).



DIRECTOR OF FOOTBALL

Tiago Pinto

Joined April 2024 (ex-Roma, Benfica)

Pure football decisions. Owns recruitment shortlist, agent negotiation, and squad architecture. Pinto's Benfica era set the template — buy from feeder leagues, sell to giants.



HEAD COACH

Andoni Iraola

Joined June 2023

Style-fit veto. Iraola's high-press 4-2-3-1 is non-negotiable; recruitment must serve it. Specific physical and on-ball thresholds for every position.

Summer '25: a £144.9m exit window.

Three sales to top European clubs in one window. None disrupted the league campaign that followed.

PLAYER	POSITION	TO	BOUGHT	SOLD	PROFIT	MULTIPLE
Illia Zabarnyi	CB	PSG	£24m	£57m	+£33m	2.4×
Dean Huijsen	CB	Real Madrid	£12.6m	£50m	+£37.4m	4.0×
Milos Kerkez	LB	Liverpool	£15.5m	£40m	+£24.5m	2.6×
Dominic Solanke	ST	Tottenham (Aug '24)	£19m	£65m	+£46m	3.4×
Other	—	Various	—	£17.9m	—	—
TOTAL · 4 NAMED + AGGREGATE				£229.9m	+£140.9m	

Reinvested at scale. Targeted everywhere.

ILLUSTRATIVE NEW SIGNINGS • SUMMER '25 • £m

Petrović (GK, Chelsea)	£14m	Backup → starter pipeline
Truffert (LB, Rennes)	£18m	Kerkez replacement
Milosavljević (CB, Red Star)	£12m	Huijsen replacement, U-19
Kroupi (ST, Lorient)	£14m	Multi-club graduate, Solanke depth
Ünal (ST, Getafe)	£19m	Striker rotation
Diakité (CB, Sunderland)	£22m	PL-ready CB pairing

£99m

BUY SPEND

£144.9m – £99m = +
£45.9m

Net cash positive. Squad rebuilt. Six U-26 internationals added.

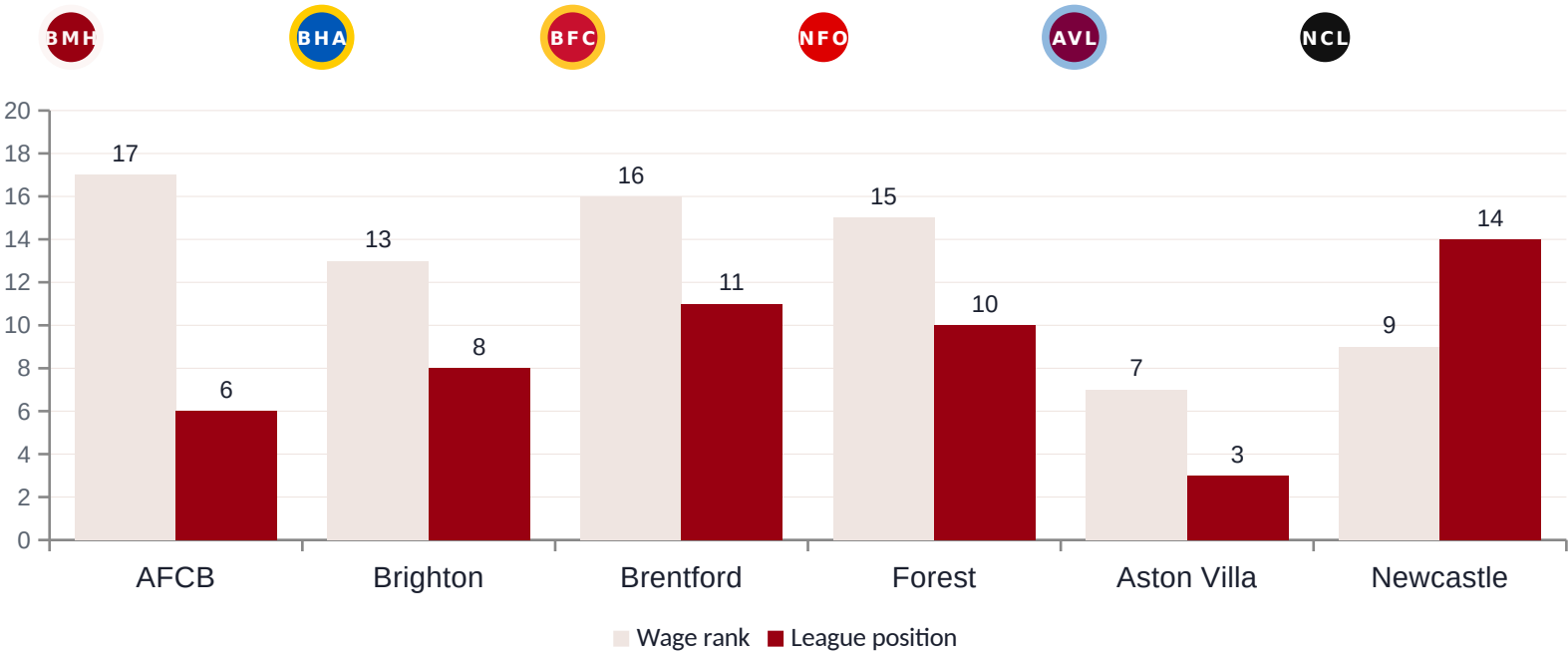
Bournemouth doesn't play alone.

Black Knight Football Club operates AFCB plus three feeder/sister clubs across Europe and Oceania.



Bournemouth gets more table from less wage.

WAGE BILL RANK vs. LEAGUE POSITION • 2025-26



11

places

Outperformance: 6th on the table from a 17th-ranked wage bill.

£0.98m

Wage cost per league point — lowest in the Premier League.

+12

xG over-performance — fifth-best in the league.

1.5%

Squad turnover by fee — focused and disciplined.

Smart-money cohort: Bournemouth, Brighton, Brentford.

	 AFCB	 BRIGHTON	 BRENTFORD
Recruitment philosophy	Pinto + data team (continental Europe)	Bloom data engine (global, deep markets)	Smartodds, set-pieces (Scandinavia, Championship)
Avg buy age	22.7	21.8	23.5
Avg buy fee	£14.2m	£17.1m	£12.4m
3-year sales total	£228m	£412m	£196m
3-year net profit	+£86m	+£166m	+£72m
Multi-club?	Yes (BKFC, 4 clubs)	Union SG (Belgium)	No
League position '25-26	6th	8th	11th
Cost / point	£0.98m	£1.44m	£1.18m

Cost per point uses 2025-26 reported wage bills divided by Premier League points (May '26).

What could break the model.



Iraola loss

His system is the development engine. A coaching change without continuity rewires the entire pipeline.

MITIGATION

Mitigation: documented playing identity; like-for-like succession profile in the Iraola coaching tree.



Pinto exit

Director-of-Football continuity is rare in football. The market for Pinto from a top-five league is open.

MITIGATION

Mitigation: scouting structure (not individual) carries the IP; deputy bench in place.



Saturated talent pools

Other smart clubs (Brighton, Brentford, Sporting) are hunting the same Ligue 2 / Eredivisie U-23 cohort.

MITIGATION

Mitigation: multi-club access opens lower-visibility leagues (Scottish Premiership, A-League, NZ).



Star injuries

A key sale rests on a Premier League highlight reel. Long-term injury can collapse a £40m transfer to £15m overnight.

MITIGATION

Mitigation: insurance; depth charts; positional duplication policy after each major sale.

Reproducible — but not without discipline.

01 Sentiment is the enemy

Selling at the first peak demands the willingness to lose a fan favourite. Most clubs flinch and lose 50% of the value.

02 The owner sets the metabolism

Foley runs AFCB like a portfolio. PSR-aware. Multi-club. Patient. Boards that need vanity wins can't run this play.

03 Coaching is recruitment

Iraola is the exit-velocity machine. Without a coach who reliably elevates players, the trading thesis collapses.

04 Pipeline beats stars

It's not the £50m sale that matters — it's the certainty that the next one is already growing in the squad.

*"Bournemouth aren't a club
punching above their weight.
They're a club that figured out
the new weight class first."*

Sources & disclosure

DATA SOURCES

- Transfermarkt — squad market values, transfer fees, contract data
- Premier League official site & FBref — points, goals, xG, wages
- BBC Sport, Athletic, Sky Sports — qualitative reporting on Iraola era and Pinto appointment
- AFCB official communications and Black Knight Football Club press releases
- Companies House and FA filings for Black Knight ownership structure

METHODOLOGY

Cost per point: latest reported wage bill ÷ 2025-26 PL points as of May 2026. Profit calculations use reported transfer fees plus add-ons where disclosed. Some signing fees illustrative.

DISCLOSURE

Portfolio piece — not commissioned by AFC Bournemouth or Black Knight Football Club. Brand colours referenced. Public data only.